

Assessment	Test	Domain	Skill	Difficulty
SAT	Reading and Writing	Standard English Conventions	Boundaries	Easy

Question

The life spans of rockfish vary greatly by species. For instance, the colorful calico rockfish (*Sebastes dallii*) can survive for a little over a _____ the roughey rockfish (*Sebastes aleutianus*) boasts a maximum life span of about two centuries.

Which choice completes the text so that it conforms to the conventions of Standard English?

Answer

- A. decade: while
- B. decade. While
- C. decade; while
- D. decade, while

Correct Answer: D

Rationale

Choice D is the best answer. The convention being tested is punctuation between a main clause and a subordinate clause. This choice correctly uses a comma to mark the boundary between the main clause ("the colorful...decade") and the subordinate clause ("while...centuries") that provides contrasting information about the life span of roughey rockfish.

Choice A is incorrect because a colon can't be used in this way to join a main clause and a subordinate clause. Choice B is incorrect because it results in a rhetorically unacceptable sentence fragment beginning with "while." Choice C is incorrect because a semicolon can't be used in this way to join a main clause and a subordinate clause.